

Online Appendix to

From Preferences to Reciprocity: Firm Adjustment after the EU–Ecuador Free Trade Agreement

1 Empirical Strategy

1.1 Data and Estimation Sample

The estimation panel combines monthly customs records from the Central Bank of Ecuador with annual financial statements filed with the *Superintendencia de Compañías, Valores y Seguros*. The customs records identify firms' imports and exports by product, trading partner, and country of origin or destination using the ten-digit NANDINA classification. The financial statements provide information on sales, material costs, employment, wages, capital, value added, and other firm characteristics.

After harmonizing firm identifiers across the two administrative sources, customs transactions are aggregated to the firm-year level and linked to the corresponding financial statements. The analysis covers 2014–2023. The year 2022 is excluded because the underlying customs records for that year are incomplete.

The empirical analysis focuses on firms importing from the European Union in Manufacturing and Wholesale & Retail. These are the sectors in which changes in European sourcing and access to imported goods are most directly relevant. The estimation sample varies slightly across outcomes because employment and some financial variables are not reported for every firm-year observation. The year-specific sample sizes used in each specification are reported in Tables 1, 2, and 3.

1.2 Identification Strategy

The EU–Ecuador Trade Agreement did not primarily create new export opportunities for Ecuadorian firms. Preferential access to the European market had already been provided under the GSP+ regime, so the agreement largely preserved and formalized that access. The main new policy margin operated on the import side through the gradual reduction of Ecuador's tariffs on goods sourced from the European Union. The firm-level effects studied here are therefore expected to arise mainly through changes in European sourcing, input access, and production decisions.

Our identification strategy combines two sources of variation. The first is cross-sectional variation in firms' exposure to European imports, measured before Ecuador's own trade-policy distortions altered firms' sourcing decisions. We construct firms' import shares using 2014 data, the last clean year before the safeguard import surcharges introduced in March 2015 changed the relative cost of imported goods. Those safeguards were broad-based, affected roughly one-third of imports, and remained in place until their gradual phase-out between 2016 and June 2017 (Uribe-Terán et al., 2025).

The second source of variation is the time path of product-specific tariff reductions established by the trade agreement. For this component, 2016 is the relevant reference year because it is the last year before the agreement entered into force. Thus, 2014 is used to define predetermined firm-level exposure weights, while 2016 is used to define the pre-agreement tariff baseline.

The outcome equation of interest can be written as

$$\Delta y_{it} = \alpha_t + \beta_t \Delta m_{it} + \delta'_t X_i + \varepsilon_{it}, \quad (1)$$

where Δy_{it} denotes the change in the log outcome of interest for firm i between year t and 2014, Δm_{it} is the corresponding change in the firm's log imports from the European Union, and X_i is a vector of predetermined firm characteristics measured at baseline. The specifications also include industry and province fixed effects.

Because both the endogenous regressor and the dependent variables are expressed as log changes, β_t can be interpreted as an elasticity. It measures the percentage change in a firm outcome associated with a 1 percent policy-induced change in imports from Europe.

Estimating equation (1) by ordinary least squares would not generally yield a causal interpretation. Changes in EU imports may reflect not only tariff reductions, but also firm-specific demand shocks, product upgrading, or endogenous sourcing decisions. Consequently, Δm_{it} may be correlated with unobserved determinants of firm performance.

To address this problem, we construct a shift-share instrument that combines firms' pre-policy import structures with the tariff reductions established by the agreement. Formally, the instrument is

$$z_{it} = \sum_k \omega_{ik} \Delta \log(1 + \tau_{kt}), \quad (2)$$

where ω_{ik} is firm i 's share of imports from the European Union accounted for by ten-digit NANDINA product k in 2014, and $\Delta \log(1 + \tau_{kt})$ is the change in the log tariff-inclusive price of product k relative to its 2016 level. The tariff change is determined by the statutory phase-out schedule of the trade agreement.

Intuitively, z_{it} measures the tariff-induced shock that each firm would face if its pre-agreement import basket remained fixed. Firms whose 2014 baskets were concentrated in products subject to larger tariff reductions receive larger predicted reductions in tariff-inclusive import prices (Borusyak et al., 2025; Goldsmith-Pinkham et al., 2020).

The corresponding first-stage equation is

$$\Delta m_{it} = \lambda_t + \theta_t z_{it} + \gamma_t' X_i + \mu_{it}. \quad (3)$$

The coefficient θ_t measures the response of imports from the European Union to changes in tariff-inclusive prices. Because both variables are expressed as log changes, it can be interpreted as an import-demand elasticity.

Identification rests on two principal conditions. The first is relevance: the tariff-based instrument must generate meaningful variation in firms' imports from the European Union. Table 1 reports the first-stage coefficient, its standard error, the Kleibergen–Paap rk Wald F statistic, and the Kleibergen–Paap rk LM statistic for each estimation year.

The second condition is the exclusion restriction. Conditional on baseline controls and fixed effects, the tariff-based exposure measure must affect firm outcomes through the changes in European sourcing induced by the agreement rather than through other firm-specific shocks correlated with firms' 2014 import baskets.

Two features of the design support this interpretation. First, the share component of the instrument is predetermined because it is fixed using firms' 2014 import baskets, before the safeguard policy and the trade agreement altered subsequent sourcing decisions. Second, the shift component is generated by the statutory product-level tariff phase-out, which is common across firms importing the same product and does not respond to individual firm performance.

In addition, the agreement largely preserved the preferential access that Ecuadorian exports already had under GSP+. This reduces concern that the instrument captures a new export-demand shock operating simultaneously through firms' pre-agreement import structures. Nevertheless, the exclusion restriction remains an identifying assumption: the design requires that, conditional on the included controls and fixed effects, firms' differential exposure to the tariff schedule affects their outcomes primarily through tariff-induced changes in imports from Europe.

The second-stage equation is

$$\Delta y_{it} = \alpha_t + \beta_t \widehat{\Delta m_{it}} + \delta_t' X_i + \varepsilon_{it}, \quad (4)$$

Table 1. *First-Stage Estimates and IV Diagnostics*

	Changes in imports from Europe between t and 2014					
	2017	2018	2019	2020	2021	2023
<i>Panel A: Common estimation sample for TFP, value added, sales, material costs, wages, and capital</i>						
Instrument coefficient	−4.261*** (0.972)	−3.428*** (0.994)	−4.144*** (1.292)	−5.020*** (1.415)	−7.361*** (1.359)	−8.426*** (1.488)
Kleibergen–Paap rk Wald F	19.215	11.897	10.293	12.588	29.345	32.074
Kleibergen–Paap rk LM	10.942	6.071	9.124	5.930	9.161	11.123
Industry and province FE	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Controls	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Observations	1,762	1,722	1,599	1,461	1,541	1,423
<i>Panel B: Employment</i>						
Instrument coefficient	−3.802*** (1.296)	−3.056*** (1.126)	−3.582*** (1.296)	−4.905*** (1.310)	−7.197*** (1.483)	−8.191*** (1.474)
Kleibergen–Paap rk Wald F	8.606	7.373	7.638	14.028	23.544	30.888
Kleibergen–Paap rk LM	9.004	5.498	7.684	6.245	9.394	10.474
Industry and province FE	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Controls	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Observations	1,611	1,579	1,476	1,361	1,428	1,313

Note. The table reports the first-stage coefficient on the tariff-based shift-share instrument and the main instrumental-variables diagnostics for the specifications used to estimate the effects of changes in imports from Europe on firm outcomes. In each year t , the endogenous regressor is the change in log imports from Europe between year t and 2014. The first stage regresses this variable on the shift-share instrument, baseline firm-level controls, three-digit industry fixed effects, and province fixed effects. Standard errors, reported in parentheses, are clustered at the three-digit ISIC industry level. The Kleibergen–Paap rk LM statistic assesses underidentification, while the Kleibergen–Paap rk Wald F statistic provides information about instrument strength. The same first-stage estimates and diagnostics apply to the 2SLS, LIML, and Fuller(1) estimators because they use the same instrument set and estimation sample within each outcome-year cell. Panel A presents the common estimation sample for total factor productivity, value added, sales, material costs, wages, and capital. Panel B reports the corresponding results for employment, which is estimated using a slightly smaller sample. Data for 2022 are excluded because the underlying customs records are incomplete. Significance levels are denoted by $*p < 0.10$, $**p < 0.05$, and $***p < 0.01$. Source: Authors’ calculations based on customs transaction records from the Central Bank of Ecuador, annual financial statements from the *Superintendencia de Compañías, Valores y Seguros*, and the tariff schedules of the EU–Ecuador Trade Agreement.

where $\widehat{\Delta m}_{it}$ is the predicted change in imports from the European Union obtained from the first stage. Under the identifying assumptions discussed above, β_t captures the causal effect associated with the component of firms’ import growth induced by the tariff schedule.

The main chapter presents ordinary least squares estimates as descriptive benchmarks. This appendix reports two-stage least squares (2SLS), limited-information maximum likelihood (LIML), and Fuller(1) estimates. The Fuller modification is included because conventional IV estimates may be sensitive to finite-sample and weak-instrument distortions (Fuller, 1977). All specifications use the same baseline controls and fixed effects and report standard errors clustered at the three-digit ISIC industry level.

2 Formal Discussion of the Results

This section provides a formal discussion of the instrumental-variables results reported in Tables 1, 2, and 3. The discussion emphasizes three points. First, the first stage shows that the tariff schedule generated an increasingly strong response in firms’ sourcing from Europe. Second, the second-stage estimates indicate that the clearest adjustment margins concern input use and production scale rather than immediate gains in measured productivity. Third, the dynamic pattern is consistent with a gradual process in which sourcing decisions adjust before broader changes in firm performance become visible.

Table 1 shows that the instrument is relevant and that the response of firms’ imports becomes stronger

Table 2. *IV Estimates of the Effects of Changes in Imports from Europe on Main Outcomes*

		Changes in imports from Europe between t and 2014					
		2017	2018	2019	2020	2021	2023
<i>Panel A: Main outcomes</i>							
TFP	2SLS	−0.022	−0.058	−0.095	−0.004	−0.051	0.025
		(0.108)	(0.177)	(0.122)	(0.111)	(0.061)	(0.041)
	LIML	−0.022	−0.058	−0.095	−0.004	−0.051	0.025
		(0.108)	(0.177)	(0.122)	(0.111)	(0.061)	(0.041)
	Fuller(1)	−0.018	−0.048	−0.084	−0.002	−0.048	0.025
		(0.097)	(0.152)	(0.110)	(0.103)	(0.059)	(0.040)
Value added	2SLS	0.094	0.047	0.027	0.013	−0.036	0.083
		(0.099)	(0.130)	(0.099)	(0.143)	(0.099)	(0.069)
	LIML	0.094	0.047	0.027	0.013	−0.036	0.083
		(0.099)	(0.130)	(0.099)	(0.143)	(0.099)	(0.069)
	Fuller(1)	0.094	0.053	0.034	0.022	−0.030	0.084
		(0.089)	(0.112)	(0.089)	(0.133)	(0.094)	(0.067)
Industry and province FE		Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Controls		Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Observations		1, 762	1, 722	1, 599	1, 461	1, 541	1, 423

Note. The table reports instrumental-variables estimates of the effects of changes in imports from Europe on the main firm outcomes. Each column corresponds to the change between year t and 2014. The endogenous regressor is the change in log imports from Europe. Results are reported for two-stage least squares (2SLS), limited-information maximum likelihood (LIML), and LIML with the Fuller(1) modification. All specifications include baseline firm-level controls, three-digit industry fixed effects, and province fixed effects. Standard errors, reported in parentheses, are clustered at the three-digit ISIC industry level. Because the model is exactly identified, the 2SLS and LIML point estimates coincide. Data for 2022 are excluded because the underlying customs records are incomplete; 2023 is therefore the final comparison year. Significance levels are denoted by $*p < 0.10$, $**p < 0.05$, and $***p < 0.01$. Source: Authors' calculations based on customs transaction records from the Central Bank of Ecuador and annual financial statements from the *Superintendencia de Compañías, Valores y Seguros*.

over time. The first-stage coefficient is negative in every horizon and increases in absolute value between 2017 and 2023. This sign is consistent with an import-demand relationship: reductions in tariff-inclusive prices increase imports from Europe.

The diagnostics are strongest for the common estimation sample and in the later years. The employment specifications display comparatively weaker first-stage diagnostics in the earlier horizons, but instrument strength increases substantially from 2020 onward. The early employment estimates should therefore be interpreted with greater caution than the later estimates.

Economically, the strengthening of the first stage is consistent with the gradual nature of the tariff schedule. Firms do not necessarily reorganize their sourcing structures immediately when a trade agreement enters into force. Supplier substitution, contractual renegotiation, and experimentation with imported varieties may occur progressively. The stronger later first-stage estimates therefore indicate cumulative changes in procurement behavior rather than a response concentrated entirely in 2017.

The main-outcome estimates in Table 2 provide no robust evidence of immediate effects on total factor productivity or value added. Because the endogenous regressor and dependent variables are expressed as log changes, the second-stage coefficients can be interpreted as elasticities. For example, the Fuller(1) coefficient of 0.094 for value added in 2017 implies that a 10 percent policy-induced increase in imports from Europe is associated with an estimated increase of approximately 0.94 percent in value added. However, this coefficient is imprecisely estimated, as are the remaining value-added and TFP coefficients.

These results do not establish that the agreement had no effect on firm performance. Rather, they show that productivity and value-added effects cannot be distinguished statistically from zero within the available sample window. One possible interpretation is that firms altered their sourcing and input use

Table 3. *IV Estimates of the Effects of Changes in Imports from Europe on Adjustment Mechanisms*

		Changes in imports from Europe between t and 2014					
		2017	2018	2019	2020	2021	2023
<i>Panel B: Adjustment mechanisms</i>							
Sales	2SLS	0.023	0.188	0.056	−0.024	0.046	0.134**
		(0.113)	(0.167)	(0.106)	(0.118)	(0.098)	(0.055)
	LIML	0.023	0.188	0.056	−0.024	0.046	0.134*
		(0.113)	(0.167)	(0.106)	(0.118)	(0.098)	(0.055)
	Fuller(1)	0.031	0.178	0.062	−0.011	0.049	0.134**
		(0.101)	(0.146)	(0.095)	(0.109)	(0.093)	(0.054)
Material costs	2SLS	0.022	0.307	0.145	0.039	0.137	0.194***
		(0.144)	(0.205)	(0.151)	(0.118)	(0.094)	(0.064)
	LIML	0.022	0.307	0.145	0.039	0.137	0.194***
		(0.144)	(0.205)	(0.151)	(0.118)	(0.094)	(0.064)
	Fuller(1)	0.030	0.282	0.144	0.050	0.136	0.193***
		(0.129)	(0.180)	(0.137)	(0.110)	(0.090)	(0.062)
Wages	2SLS	0.194	0.155	0.171	0.024	0.013	0.060
		(0.119)	(0.214)	(0.132)	(0.129)	(0.119)	(0.072)
	LIML	0.194	0.155	0.171	0.024	0.013	0.060
		(0.119)	(0.214)	(0.132)	(0.129)	(0.119)	(0.072)
	Fuller(1)	0.181*	0.143	0.163	0.030	0.015	0.061
		(0.108)	(0.185)	(0.119)	(0.121)	(0.114)	(0.070)
Employment	2SLS	−0.004	−0.216	−0.435	0.091	0.033	0.216***
		(0.193)	(0.312)	(0.323)	(0.180)	(0.133)	(0.083)
	LIML	−0.004	−0.216	−0.435	0.091	0.033	0.216***
		(0.193)	(0.312)	(0.323)	(0.180)	(0.133)	(0.083)
	Fuller(1)	0.003	−0.173	−0.370	0.090	0.034	0.211***
		(0.166)	(0.260)	(0.283)	(0.165)	(0.127)	(0.081)
Capital	2SLS	0.013	−0.052	0.016	−0.032	−0.055	−0.002
		(0.110)	(0.133)	(0.108)	(0.089)	(0.079)	(0.066)
	LIML	0.013	−0.052	0.016	−0.032	−0.055	−0.002
		(0.110)	(0.133)	(0.108)	(0.089)	(0.079)	(0.066)
	Fuller(1)	0.018	−0.035	0.023	−0.022	−0.050	0.001
		(0.098)	(0.115)	(0.098)	(0.081)	(0.075)	(0.064)
Industry and province FE		Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Controls		Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Observations: sales, material costs, wages, and capital		1, 762	1, 722	1, 599	1, 461	1, 541	1, 423
Observations: employment		1, 611	1, 579	1, 476	1, 361	1, 428	1, 313

Note. The table reports instrumental-variables estimates of the effects of changes in imports from Europe on firm adjustment mechanisms. Each column corresponds to the change between year t and 2014. The endogenous regressor is the change in log imports from Europe. Results are reported for two-stage least squares (2SLS), limited-information maximum likelihood (LIML), and LIML with the Fuller(1) modification. All specifications include baseline firm-level controls, three-digit industry fixed effects, and province fixed effects. Standard errors, reported in parentheses, are clustered at the three-digit ISIC industry level. Because the model is exactly identified, the 2SLS and LIML point estimates coincide. Employment is estimated using a slightly smaller sample because of missing employment information. Data for 2022 are excluded because the underlying customs records are incomplete; 2023 is therefore the final comparison year. Significance levels are denoted by * $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, and *** $p < 0.01$. Source: Authors' calculations based on customs transaction records from the Central Bank of Ecuador and annual financial statements from the *Superintendencia de Compañías, Valores y Seguros*.

before the consequences of those changes appeared in measured productivity.

The absence of immediate TFP gains is not necessarily inconsistent with the literature on firm adjustment to trade liberalization. Survey contributions such as Goldberg and Pavcnik (2016), De Loecker and Goldberg (2014), and Melitz and Redding (2014) emphasize that reductions in trade costs can affect firms through multiple margins, including sourcing, input quality, production scale, markups, and selection.

A central result in the literature on imported intermediates is that access to foreign inputs may improve firm performance over time, but the relevant adjustments need not occur contemporaneously. Studies including Amiti and Konings (2007), Goldberg et al. (2010), Topalova and Khandelwal (2011), Halpern et al. (2015), Zaclicever and Pellandra (2018), and Camino-Mogro and Carrillo-Maldonado (2023) show

that imported inputs can affect firms by relaxing input constraints, expanding available varieties, and facilitating changes in production processes. The lack of statistically detectable TFP effects in the current estimates is therefore consistent with, although it does not prove, a transition in which imported-input adjustment precedes measured productivity changes.

The estimates in Table 3 are consistent with this interpretation. By 2023, a 10 percent policy-induced increase in imports from Europe is associated with an estimated 1.9 percent increase in real material costs. Sales also increase in the final horizon: a 10 percent increase in imports is associated with an estimated 1.3 percent increase in sales. The corresponding employment elasticity is approximately 0.21, implying an estimated employment increase of about 2.1 percent. By contrast, wages and capital display no stable or precisely estimated effects.

The positive coefficient for material costs does not imply that imported inputs became more expensive. Material costs measure firms' total real expenditure on materials rather than the price of each unit purchased. Total expenditure can therefore increase after tariffs fall if firms respond by purchasing larger quantities of inputs or expanding production.

Taken together, the material-cost, sales, and employment estimates suggest that the clearest observable adjustment by the final sample year occurred through input use and production scale. This interpretation is related to the scale channel discussed by Head and Ries (1999): trade reform can alter output and input demand even before stronger productivity effects become visible.

The comparison with the literature on protectionism and production networks also helps clarify the interpretation. Barattieri and Cacciatore (2023) show that trade-policy changes can propagate through production linkages and that direct and indirect exposure may produce different firm responses. Likewise, De Loecker et al. (2016) emphasize that changes in trade policy need not translate one-for-one into immediate productivity gains because firms may initially adjust through marginal costs, prices, pass-through, and markups.

The estimates in this appendix indicate a gradual reorganization of sourcing patterns. The first-stage response strengthens over time, while statistically robust effects on materials, sales, and employment are observed in the final horizon. This pattern is consistent with a process in which firms require time to change suppliers, renegotiate contracts, adapt production, and make use of newly accessible imported varieties.

This dynamic interpretation is particularly relevant because the tariff reductions were phased in over several years. The relevant empirical question is therefore not whether all possible gains appeared immediately in 2017, but whether the sequence of estimated effects is consistent with gradual firm adjustment. The evidence suggests that sourcing responds first and that input use, sales, and employment become more responsive over time. This interpretation is also consistent with Bas and Ledezma (2020) and Impullitti et al. (2022), who emphasize that the effects of trade liberalization can be dynamic and heterogeneous across firms.

Overall, the results support a gradual transmission mechanism. The agreement first changed firms' sourcing from Europe, and the later estimates show corresponding increases in material use, sales, and employment. The absence of statistically detectable TFP effects is consistent with an adjustment process that remained incomplete within the available sample window. It does not, however, establish that productivity gains will necessarily emerge after 2023.

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